

Reflection on GradCafe Data:

While websites like GradCafe can provide a large amount of open-source data to parse through and analyze, it is an inherently biased source that does not provide the full picture of the graduate application process. GradCafe suffers greatly from self-reporting and volunteer bias, this is an elective website that not all grad school applicants know about and therefore representative of a, likely, more score-focused “competitive” applicant. This can skew GPA, acceptances, and GRE scores higher. Additionally, since there are no filters, people can submit false data or submit acceptances under fake universities and programs. For example, a SQL based analysis of the latest 30,000 entries on GradCafe report and average GRE score of 260.5 for those that reported one. The highest score one can receive on this test is a 160. It is likely that people are putting in their combined GRE Q and GRE V scores, as a score out of 340 is sometimes used. After a quick check on the website, there is no limit to the number you can enter for GRE score. This causes inaccurate data which makes it much harder, and likely impossible, to calculate an accurate average GRE.

Additionally, Gradcafe fails to allow for the influence of context. For example, a student might have been accepted to a program with lower-than-average scores, but perhaps they applied to dozens of grad schools which increased their odds of getting in somewhere. In this instance, the numbers do not adequately represent this applicant. Furthermore, it is impossible to represent the influence an in-person interview has on acceptances. Scores alone are not a guarantee to be accepted into more competitive positions where relationships with professors are part of the process.